How do animals reproduce?

Background

fertilisation (say 'furr-til-iz-ay-shen') – the merging (joining) of the male and female reproductive cells

species (say 'spee-seas') – a group of living things that can breed together to produce fertile offspring

Animals come in all shapes and sizes. Most of them reproduce through **sexual reproduction**, but they **breed** and have their young in many different ways.

Two partners

Sexual reproduction requires two partners of the opposite sex. Because of this, all species that reproduce sexually come in two different forms: males and females. An important principle of sexual reproduction is that the male and female must be of the same species if they are to successfully reproduce.

In some species, males and females look very different. In other species, the differences are not so obvious.

☞ **1** Fill in the gaps in the table, naming the female and male forms of these animals. Leave the final column blank for now.

Animal	Female form	Male form	
human	w_____	m_____	
c_____	hen	r_____	
elephant	b_____	c_____	
h_____	m_____	stallion	
s_____	ewe	r_____	

2 a) Name two types of animals that have male and female forms that look quite different.

_____ _____

b) Why do you think the male and female forms look different?

_____

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How do animals reproduce? CONT'D

Fertilisation and offspring

Many animals that reproduce sexually **mate**. This means that the male fertilises the egg of the female inside the female, as in human reproduction. Other animals, such as frogs and some fish, fertilise the female's eggs outside her body, after they have been laid.

The single fertilised cell begins to divide and a foetus begins to grow. The foetus spends time growing inside the female – called **gestation** in most animals or **pregnancy** in humans – or it may grow inside an egg that has been laid. After a certain amount of time, the new offspring is either born or hatches from the egg.

Mammals give birth to live offspring. Reptiles, birds, fish and insects hatch from eggs.

3 **a)** Fill in the second column of the table by writing two examples of each type of animal.

b) Fill in the third column of the table by writing 'egg' (if the offspring usually hatches from an egg) or 'live baby' (if the offspring is born from the mother).

Animal type	Two examples	Egg or live baby	
mammals			
reptiles			
birds			
fish			
insects			

4 Go back to Question 1. Write the heading 'Offspring' in the fourth column of the table and write in the name given for each type of offspring.

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